

Ohio River Trail moves toward first construction stages

By Bill Utterback butterback@timesonline.com | Posted: Thursday, March 28, 2013 7:00 pm

CENTER TWP. — When Dr. Vince Troia slides “complete” into a conversation concerning the Ohio River Trail Council, interest accelerates. Questions surface.

“The feasibility studies have been completed,” he said. And what have they revealed?

“It’s feasible,” he said.

A biking/running/

walking trail that would cover more than 40 miles, mostly along the Ohio

and Beaver rivers, and stretch from the Pennsylvania/Ohio line to the Montour Trail in western Allegheny County, can work.

When?

“If I had \$20 million, we could do it in a year,” he said. Without the \$20 million gift?

“It’s a 20-year project,” he said Thursday afternoon at a public open house at the Community

College of Beaver County.

Construction is one state Department of Conservation and Natural Resources grant away from beginning. The first stage — to be completed within the next five years, possibly sooner — will run from the Montour Trail in Robinson Township through Coraopolis and on to the Sewickley Bridge.

Troia said there are people — outside the ORTC — who imagine a trail that runs from Sewickley, through Edgeworth, Leetsdale and Ambridge, crosses the Ambridge-Aliquippa bridge, and rejoins the proposed ORTC trail again.

The first Beaver County stage to be constructed, according to Troia, will likely begin in Monaca, cross the Monaca-Rochester Bridge, move through Rochester’s

Riverfront Park and cross the under-construction Veterans' Bridge. The main trail will continue through Bridgewater and Beaver toward Ohio.

A new proposal under consideration would provide an alternative trail from the Veterans' Bridge into Bradys Run Park.

There is no timetable for the first Beaver County leg. A portion passing through West Aliquippa may also be the first Beaver County stage constructed.

Troia also slid "complete" into a conversation involving the ORTC's water trails map, which shows all the access points for kayaks or other water craft, on the Ohio River, the Beaver River, and Beaver Creek, which spills into the Ohio River in Glasgow.

The water trails map, available at the ORTC website, contains many details, including historic sites along the rivers and the locations of Audubon Society-designated important bird areas.

Troia was especially encouraged about the inclusion of Beaver Creek. He thinks the map will introduced the area to kayakers and others who are familiar with the Beaver and Ohio rivers.

"Kayaking (Beaver Creek) is like being in heaven," he said. "It's very peaceful. You see eagles and hawks. Hardly anybody knows about it."